



**player keep in mind in this regard?**

Many of our athletes only become aware of sports science and the requirements of a high-performance environment after entering the national set-up. Ideally, these aspects should be introduced by the time they turn 18. This is a basic requirement that we lack. I'm not saying players need expensive sports equipment—there are other products in the market that are just as effective.

We already place a strong emphasis on hockey skills, but skill is only one element of performance. There are several other crucial aspects — nutrition, digestion, and even recovery related to the menstrual cycle, which remains a taboo topic.

**While we are on this subject, there have been a few players who admitted that it's difficult to be completely honest with the coach when it comes to discussing periods...**

Yes, but this needs to change because a coach should know. It's a natural process. If I don't know when my players are going through their

menstrual cycle and how much pain they're experiencing, how can I plan their training and recovery?

Many players endure severe pain during these five to six days. If I'm unaware of this and schedule a high-intensity session, the athlete is bound to break down at some point. That's not beneficial for either the individual or the team.

This awareness needs to start at the Under-14 or even Under-13 level, when the body undergoes significant biological changes. By the time players reach the national level, they shouldn't feel shy about discussing these things with the coach, and vice versa. To me, these girls are like my daughters.

**What happens when a key player gets her period on an important matchday?**

We track the date, cycle, and correlate the data. A "red session" is a training period designed to match the intensity of a real game. Over six to seven months, we monitor how much effort a player puts in while enduring 100 per cent pain from abdominal cramps. If the output isn't sufficient, I have to balance her time

on and off the pitch effectively.

It's all about mindset. If a player can meet expectations during a red session, she can replicate the same performance in a match. This process not only builds confidence but also strengthens the trust between coach and player.

**Is there anything that you have already implemented from your learnings in the USA, where you held your last job?**

Yes, things like documentation and sharing of a lot of data. It's a cultural change because earlier, there were hardly any discussions, and the girls were kept in the dark regarding why they were being dropped or what they were lacking. I didn't learn much about hockey in the USA from the sport's point of view, but the entire ecosystem is so much better there.

I discussed this with Hockey India, and I am grateful to them and the Sports Authority of India because they immediately provided me with the things I wanted, such as the athlete monitoring system. It helps all athletes track their progress —'What have I done today? How